However, the violence in Nepal wasn't directed solely towards the ruling regime. The protesters attacked leaders across party lines, including former prime ministers Sher Bahadur Deuba and Jhalanath Khanal. Khanal's wife, Rajyalaxmi Chitrakar, succumbed to the burn injuries she sustained when the mob set their house afire. The Supreme Court and a five-star hotel in the heart of Kathmandu were torched too, signalling that youth anger went beyond the political establishment. Other major cities and towns saw youth protest government high-handedness. Only when Nepali army chief Gen. Ashok Raj Sigdel called for an end to violence and ordered his troops to patrol the city was calm restored. Now comes the hard part.

CRAFTING A NEW DISPENSATION

It was a pattern that echoed Sri Lanka's crisis playbook more than Bangladesh's or Pakistan's coup-prone history: the military as backbone, not sovereign. Major General Binoj Basnyat, a former general-officer-commanding of the Eastern Division of the Nepali army, is clear that the armed forces always follow the constitutional arrangement and harbour no political ambitions. "This has been the defining character of the army," says Basnyat, "instilled through its upbringing and institutional culture. Whenever the army is entrusted with the responsibility of upholding constitutional rights, it fulfils that role." Manjeev Singh Puri, a former Indian ambassador to Nepal, agrees. "The Nepali army knows the country's proud struggle for democracy by overthrowing the monarchy," he says. "Their army has the same ethos as the Indian Army. If someone asked an Indian Army general to take over the country, would he?"

THE NEPALI ARMY, SAYS AN EXPERT, HAS THE SAME ETHOS AS THE INDIAN ARMY. "IF SOMEONE ASKED AN INDIAN ARMY GENERAL TO TAKE OVER, WOULD HE?"

Instead, Puri expects a techno-political government that is a mix of professionals, bureaucrats, economists and judicial experts besides younger political voices to be part of the new power structure. In line with that thinking, Sigdel is believed to have persuaded the 73-year-old Sushila Karki, a former Supreme Court chief justice, who had openly come out in support of the protests, to be the head of an interim arrangement. However, he soon found it difficult to hammer out a consensus, since Gen Z are a disparate group of protesters with no major leader at the forefront. A few of the protesters were rooting for Kathmandu mayor Balendra Shah, the 35-year-old rapper who has a fan following among the youth and had campaigned for changing the ruling establishment through his songs. Kulman Ghisin, the 54-year-old former managing director of the Nepal Electricity Authority, is another contender. Ghisin is credited with overhauling the country's electricity grid. Nevertheless, like Sri Lanka in 2024, any interim dispensation in Nepal will have to work towards eventually establishing a democratically elected government that meets the aspirations of the young.

A PROTEST IN THE MAKING

The immediate trigger for Gen Z's rebellion was Nepal's peremptory ban on 26 major social media platforms, including Facebook, Instagram, WhatsApp, YouTube, X, Reddit and LinkedIn. The Oli government blocked these for their failure to meet the one-week deadline to register locally, designate grievance officers and establish a point of contact as India had done two years ago. Nepali officials argue they were simply enforcing a Supreme Court-aligned directive and sovereignty over digital space. But for millions of Nepalis—especially the young—social media platforms are not a luxury; they are critical tools for livelihood, communication and a lifeline to family and opportunity abroad. In fact, Nepal has one of South Asia's highest users of social media platforms. Within hours of the blackout, anger boiled over into the street and ended in regime change.

The resentment, though, did not come out of nowhere. "The signs were there for a long, long time," says Ranjit Rae, another former Indian ambassador to Nepal. "There's huge



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